



MASTER of ARTS (HONS) IN LIBERAL STUDIES (MLS) HANDBOOK

GUIDELINES FOR STUDENTS
Academic Year 2024-2025

The Master of Arts (Hons) in Liberal Studies

The Master of Arts (Hons) in Liberal Studies (MLS) at Ashoka University is a **38-credit, one-year programme** taken by students who have graduated with a postgraduate diploma in Liberal Studies (through the Young India Fellowship at Ashoka University) and have been accepted by an Ashoka University department (or departments) and faculty supervisor (or supervisors) to work on a specific research dissertation or project. Since the programme is not affiliated with one specific department, students may register for courses and engage in projects from a variety of disciplines—including the humanities, social sciences and natural sciences—as well as in interdisciplinary projects. Depending on the nature of the project, students may be required to complete suitable coursework offered in one or several departments.

The purpose of a Master of Arts (Hons) in Liberal Studies is to help students ground themselves in one or more disciplines and to familiarise them with research experience characteristic of their chosen field/s. The programme aims to help students prepare themselves for further studies or any occupation that requires strong research skills.

MLS Students design their own curriculum in consultation with their supervisor, and often choose to work on projects across two or more disciplines. They also provide teaching and/or research assistance to their department/s of affiliation.

In the course of the year, students complete an original work of research, writing or performance, which culminates in a Master's Dissertation or a creative project.

Eligibility & Admissions

The Master of Arts (Hons) in Liberal Studies (MLS) programme is currently restricted to graduates of the **Young India Fellowship**, a one-year postgraduate diploma programme in Liberal Studies hosted by Ashoka University. Young India Fellows are eligible to join the MLS programme up to two years after their graduation. Admission to the MLS programme is only in the Monsoon Semester.

In order to apply to the MLS programme, Young India Fellows need to submit the following documents:

- 1. Curriculum Vitae (CV)**
- 2. Provisional YIF Transcript**

3. **Research Statement** (minimum 800 words, maximum 1,500 words).

The Research Statement must describe the applicant's proposed Dissertation/Final Project, explain what makes it unique, and demonstrate how the applicant proposes to complete the project satisfactorily within the 12-month MLS year. The Research Statement must also include a minimum of 4-5 references; full citations must be provided at the end of the statement. The reference/citation list or bibliography will not be included in the overall word count. The statement should have a **cover page**, with the following information on it:

- The applicant's full name, as per the YIF records,
- Their preferred contact email ID (mandatory) and contact phone number (optional),
- The title of the proposed dissertation/project and the intended Concentration/s, which should relate to Major/Minor department/s at Ashoka,
- The name and signature of the applicant's intended supervisor/s. E-signatures are accepted.

*Letters of Recommendation are **not** required.*

Course structure and graduation requirements

The MLS is a **38-credit** programme that includes the following semester-wise course-requirement format:

Mandatory courses:

- 1st semester (Monsoon):
 - Independent Research Methodologies (**4 credits**)
 - Dissertation Proposal (**2 credits**)
- 2nd Semester (Spring):
 - Dissertation I – (**4 credits** – 1st draft)
- 3rd Semester (Summer)
 - Dissertation II (**4 credits** – 2nd and final draft)
- Additionally, **4 credits** must be earned over the course of the programme from any combination of 2-credit Research Practicums (RPs) and/or Teaching Practicums (TPs); only 2 of these credits may be completed in the summer.
- **Total credits from the above-listed mandatory courses: 18**
- **The remaining 20 credits may be earned by taking UG/PG courses in the 1st (Monsoon) or 2nd (Spring) semesters.**
- **Minimum credits per Monsoon/Spring semester: 12**
- **Maximum credits per Monsoon/Spring semester: 26**
- **Minimum/Maximum credits per Summer semester: 4/6 (only Dissertation II and 1 TP/RP)**

Note I: The above details constitute the minimum requirements for the satisfactory completion of the MLS programme. Individual departments/supervisors might choose to require students to take specific courses, submit more drafts of the Dissertation/Final Project, seek approval from a committee, or that students make one or more formal presentations of their work.

Note II: Courses can be distributed over the monsoon and spring semesters, except Independent Research Methodologies (IRM), which is compulsory for the Monsoon semester, and the Dissertation/ Final Project-related courses, which must be completed in the sequence described above.

Note III: Several departments have a graduate seminar for ASP (fourth-year) students. Where these seminars exist, MLS students enrolled in Independent Research Methodologies (IRM) might be asked to join them. In such instances, the credits for this course will count for IRM credits. Students must decide on the course they will be taking to fulfil the IRM requirement in consultation with their supervisors.

Note IV: Students can take extra courses in the Monsoon and Spring semesters of their MLS year, with the approval of their supervisors, subject to a maximum of 26 credits per semester.

Note V: Field-work may be completed over the mid- and end-semester breaks.

The Dissertation/ Final Project: The Dissertation or Final Project is the cornerstone of the MLS programme. Students will work through the year on a Dissertation or original research project under the supervision of a faculty member from their chosen Concentration department. The dissertation format (word length, scope, etc.) will be determined by the supervisor and the department and might, therefore, vary across departments. In certain cases, the final product might be a creative project, a performance, or a piece of original writing.

Research Practicum (RP): This is a two-credit course (up to two 2-credit RPs can be counted towards fulfilling MLS credit requirements) in which the student assists the supervisor or any other Ashoka faculty on an agreed-upon research project. The student will assist a faculty member in their research area(s). Students who complete two RPs may provide research assistance on the same project through a semester or the entire year, or on two separate projects in the same semester or across two semesters. The Research Practicum is determined by faculty, under the guidance of the supervisor or the Head of the Department, who approves the RP.

The OAA will keep a record of the details of MLS students' RPs; it is the students' responsibility to communicate in a timely manner regarding research projects that they will be working on. It is also the students' responsibility to notify the OAA in case

of changes in projects. Such changes are subject to the supervisor and/or Head of Department's approval.

Teaching Practicum (TP): This is a two-credit teaching assistantship (up to two 2-credit TPs can be counted towards fulfilling MLS credit requirements) in which students provide logistical and pedagogical assistance to a faculty member in their department of affiliation. In case TPs are not available in their department, students may apply for TP positions in other departments, excluding the YIF. Teaching Practicums are coordinated at the department level.

Evaluations

For every course except TPs, the student will receive a final letter grade. These grades are calibrated to GPA quality points. The percentage scores that will equate to these grades is decided by individual faculty. There is no standard conversion of grades into percentages.

Academic Integrity Policy

Writing that borrows from another person's work without appropriate acknowledgment challenges the academic integrity of a university community. Violating academic integrity is a serious offence, must be reported, may become a part of the concerned student's permanent file and is generally met with severe disciplinary action. The concerned student may also be required to complete a workshop on academic integrity.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q 1: Can I take courses outside my department?

Yes, you can, with the approval of the concerned department and your supervisor.

Q 2: Can I be affiliated with a research centre at Ashoka?

Yes, you can. Ashoka Centres have allowed MLS students to affiliate with them in the past. You must, however, be primarily affiliated with a department.

Q 3: Can I get an extension on the Dissertation, or on the programme as a whole?

UGC norms enable you to complete the MLS within three years after the completion of the Young India Fellowship. This means that students who begin their MLS immediately after graduating from the YIF programme are eligible for a two-year extension; students who begin their MLS following a one-year gap after graduating from the YIF programme are eligible for a one-year extension, and students who begin their MLS following a two-year gap after graduating from the YIF programme are not eligible for any extension.

Q 4: Can I do my Research Practicum and Teaching Practicum outside my department?

You can do your RP and TP outside your department, with the approval of your supervisor.

Q 5: Can I be a Teaching Assistant for YIF?

You may choose to be a TA for YIF, but these TA-ships cannot count towards MLS credits and, therefore, cannot be substituted for the MLS TP requirements. They will also not show up in the MLS transcript. This is something you might choose to do as an extra activity.

Q 6: Do I need to do my Research Practicum with my supervisor?

Ideally, you should do your RP with your supervisor. However, you can do your RP with any other Ashoka faculty member in or outside your department, subject to the approval of your supervisor.

Q 7: Can my research practicum be connected to my dissertation topic?

Yes, it can; subject to your supervisor's approval.

Q 8: My department's faculty don't really need Research Assistants. What do I do?

Some departments don't always need Research Assistants. They will have to find some project to associate you with, on different formats (it could be helping with a performance or a project in the performing arts, for example). You may also secure a Research Practicum outside your department, with the approval of your supervisor.

Q 9: I cannot find a Research Practicum. What do I do?

You can substitute one or two Research Practicums (2 credits each) with a UG/PG course (4 credits). However, you will have to then take one or two (as the case may be) Teaching Practicum course/s to ensure that you meet your overall requirement of 4 RP/TP credits.

Q 10: I cannot get a Teaching Practicum. What do I do?

You can substitute one or two Teaching Practicums (2 credits each) with a UG/PG course (4 credits). However, you will have to then take one or two (as the case may be) Research Practicum course/s to ensure that you meet your overall requirement of 4 RP/TP credits.

Q 11: How many courses can I take as an MLS student during a year?

You must take the required number of courses needed to collect the 38 credits required for the degree, including the compulsory courses as per the schedule detailed above. You can take additional courses, subject to the maximum credits allowed per semester, as detailed above. Your grade in every course that you enrol for will be counted towards your GPA and CGPA. Therefore, it is recommended that you consult your supervisor and choose your courses wisely.

Q 12: How many courses can I take for audit?

You can take a maximum of 2 audit courses per semester. You will be required to take the permission of the concerned professors and understand the specific requirements. Audit courses offer no credits, so they cannot be substituted for credit-bearing course requirements.

Q 13: Can I opt for the Pass/Fail grading system for a course?

Yes, you can opt for the Pass/Fail grading system for a maximum of 4 credits (typically one course) over the entire duration of the MLS programme. Only UG/PG courses other than the mandatory MLS courses are eligible for conversion to the P/F option; mandatory MLS courses are **not** eligible for the P/F option. You can opt to change the grading system for a course from a letter-grading system to the P/F system until the end of the 8th week of the Monsoon or Spring semesters. After this date, choices cannot be modified.

Q 14: Can I take co-curricular (CC) courses and will they count towards credit requirements?

CC courses will not count towards your credit requirements, unless you are registered with the Performing Arts Department for your Dissertation. However, you can take CC courses for audit, with the permission of your supervisor and the concerned faculty. Do remember that CC courses are mandatory for UG students, who will usually get precedence when CC course slots are allotted.

Q 15: If I finish all my coursework but need to take an extension for an extra semester to complete the Dissertation or final project, can I take extra courses as well?

Yes, but these will be on a paid basis, as per the university's fee schedule.

Q 16: Do we graduate in the discipline of our choosing?

You graduate from the Master of Arts (Hons) in Liberal Studies programme with a Concentration in the discipline(s) you are admitted to. In case that includes more than one discipline, the transcript will reflect that.

Q 17: What do I do in case of an issue with my supervisor?

If there is an issue that cannot be immediately resolved with your supervisor, you may reach out to the Head of the Department and the MLS Director. It will be your responsibility to locate an alternative supervisor, if necessary.

Q 18: I'm selected for a semester exchange programme abroad. Is this compatible with the MLS?

The only study-abroad option available to MLS students is at Sciences Po, France, in the Monsoon semester of the MLS year, as an **Ashoka-nominated student**. No other study-abroad options will be entertained. Any student who accepts an Ashoka nomination for a Sciences Po semester will need to notify the Director, MLS and also share details of how they propose to fulfill their 1st semester MLS requirements **before** they start their study-abroad semester. They will also need to obtain approvals for all their proposed courses, through the Office of Global Education and Strategic Partnerships (GESP), in accordance with GESp deadlines and other requirements. A maximum of 20 credits (5 courses) may be earned through this study-abroad semester at Sciences Po.

Q. 19: Can I take a Leave of Absence for a semester?

Exceptional circumstances, such as health- or family-related difficulties, may arise in which a student feels that the best option available to them is that of taking a Leave of Absence (LoA). To request an LOA, the student must send an email intimating their request and providing their reasons for their request to the OAA. The request must be supported by an email from the student's supervisor.

- An LoA must always be requested and can only be granted for one full semester only.

- If the request for an LoA is received within eight weeks of the start of the semester and if the request is subsequently granted, the OAA will update the student's semester status to LoA, and remove the student from all the courses they are enrolled in. As a result, the semester disappears from the student's transcript.
- If the request for an LoA is received after eight weeks of the start of the semester and if the request is subsequently granted, the semester will not be removed from the student's transcript. The OAA will withdraw the student from all courses with a WX grade.
- If, before the point in time that a request for an LoA is approved, a final grade has been given to the student for a course in the semester for which the LoA is requested, then even if the LoA is granted, that final grade will stay on the transcript.
- An LoA may not be taken during the first semester in the normal course.
- Only one LoA is permitted during the course of the MLS programme.

Q 19: Can I fail a course and will it affect my GPA/CGPA?

Yes, you can fail a course and it will affect your GPA and CGPA, while also being reflected on your transcript. You will have to pass at least as many courses (including the Dissertation/Final Project-related courses) as are necessary to complete 38 credits, besides completing the Dissertation/Final Project satisfactorily and meeting all the overall programme requirements, in order to graduate.

Q 20: Is it possible to fail the MLS?

Yes. Your department and/or supervisor/s could decide that your Dissertation/Final Project does not meet the required standards. Not meeting your credit requirements within the stipulated time (see Q3) could also prevent you from obtaining your MLS degree.

Q 21: Is there a formal Dissertation/Final Project submission date?

The final submission date should be agreed upon ahead of time between the student and the supervisor, ensuring that the supervisor has enough time to submit all final grades by the UG grade submission deadline in the graduating semester.

Q 22: What are the MLS programme dates?

The MLS Programme start date will coincide with the UG Monsoon start date and end with the following UG Summer end date, as per that year's published academic calendar.

Q 23: Is MLS recognised by UGC as a Master's programme?

Yes; otherwise we could not offer it.